

5 Marketing Moves in 2026

That Every Small Business Should Make

A practical growth playbook for local businesses that want more leads, repeat customers, and smarter marketing.

Why 2026 Looks Different:

Attention is fragmented. AI tools are mainstream. Your customers expect speed, trust, and relevance. Small businesses, especially on Long Island, can win by being faster, more personal, and more local than their competitors..

1. Own Your Customer List

Email marketing returns an average **\$36 for every \$1 spent***, making it one of the highest ROI channels. Invest in a tool like MailChimp, HubSpot or MailerLite to build a database of known customers.

Be strategic around how much data you ask your customers to give. No one wants to fill out a form with 10 fields - keep it simple from the onset.

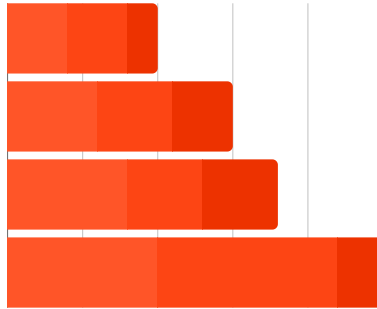
Check your most relevant KPIs frequently: email open rates, click rates, and unsubscribes.

Automate your email too much and it'll start to go flat. Make sure your newsletters are full of relevant, timely, topical and most importantly - INTERESTING - content that your customers will value!

(*Source: https://www.hubspot.com/marketing-statistics?locale=en_GB&utm_source=chatgpt.com)

Don't Do This

- Send customers marketing without their consent.
- Send out an email newsletter or an SMS without a clear Call To Action.
- Rely solely on social followers as your primary engagement channel.



Do This Instead

- Use Pop-Ups, Forms, and Receipts to capture customer emails.
- Table-Top or Window Decals with QR codes can also be a handy way of building your email database.
- Consider SMS / Text for transactional engagement.

2. Short Videos Outperform Static Posts

Video has been, and will likely continue to be the most effective format of marketing around. Yes, it may take a bit more time, but bear in mind two key points: 1) lots of tools exist to make your video production quick and easy and 2) low-fi formats (think selfie videos) are highly effective!

In fact, videos under 60 seconds generate 2.5x more engagements than static images, illustrations or infographics*.

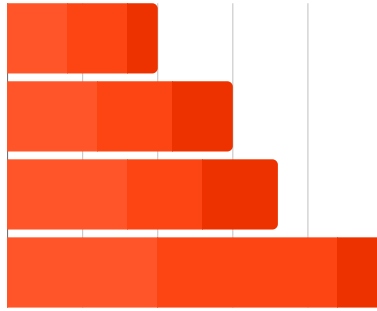
Tools like CapCut and Adobe Express are fantastic for editing, adding captions, and light post-production. They're easy to use and will elevate a raw video shot on a cell phone to the next level.

And don't forget to use your videos beyond social - your website, your Google Business listing and digital signage are all great places to show off your business!

(*Source: <https://www.digitalapplied.com/blog/video-marketing-statistics-2026-data-points>)

Don't Do This

- Spend loads of budget on highly-produced videos for your social feeds.
- Shoot in landscape (horizontal) mode - vertical is the preferred and most common format.
- Forget to add subtitles



Do This Instead

- Use behind-the-scenes takes to give glimpses of what your business is all about.
- Include testimonials and interactions with customers to prove loyalty and brand integrity

3. Your Reviews *are* your Ads!

Customer reviews are arguably more valuable than paid advertising, acting as powerful, authentic social proof that builds trust, boosts credibility, and directly influences consumer buying decisions.

They function as a "brutally honest" form of marketing that you can't totally control but *can* leverage to enhance your brand reputation and increase conversion rates. Ever see a Google Business listing with nothing but 5-star reviews? Yeah, we're pretty skeptical, too! That's why a star review alone won't cut it.

A recent study showed that 31% of consumers watch video content of everyday people talking about local businesses*.

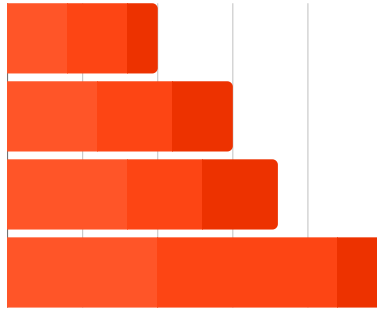
What does this look like in action?

- Video ads with screenshots of real reviews
- 15-30 second ads with real customers talking about your business and why they value it
- Before and after shots with quotes from your customers

(*Source: https://www.brightlocal.com/research/local-consumer-review-survey-2025/?utm_source=chatgpt.com)

Don't Do This

- Post generic reviews that lack any specificity.
- Fabricate reviews
- Use reviews to trash talk other businesses in your community



Do This Instead

- Ask permission from customers first before using their name or face in your marketing.
- Use surveys to build a base of feedback quotes.
- Integrate 1-2 reviews into every marketing campaign.

4. Track The Metrics That Matter

A wise man once said “if you can’t measure it, you can’t manage it.”

While marketing continues to be a blend of art and science, using data to inform your decisions (not dictate them) is a rule of thumb every small business should use.

But with so many different metrics available across every marketing channel, PLUS all of your transactional data that reflects your bottom line, where should you focus?

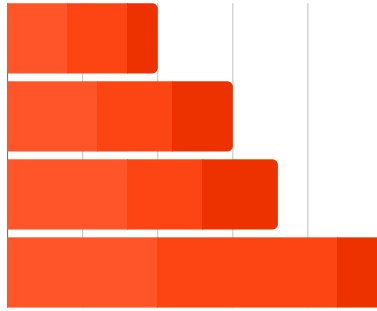
Focus on the data that matters. Stop chasing vanity metrics like Facebook likes and Instagram follows. Don’t just look at website visits alone. The algorithms today reward QUALITY content, and if it drives engagement, it will reach new customers that don’t follow your pages.

A few of our favorites:

- CAC (Customer Acquisition Cost) - aka, how much you need to spend to get a new customer. [Nextdoor](#) does a great job of breaking this down.
- Lead-to-Customer Conversion Rate
- Website traffic sources and average session durations
- Email Marketing open rate and click rate
- Social engagement rate and reach

Don't Do This

- Focus on vanity metrics like follows or likes.
- Manually track every metric - pick 5 for every channel you use and look at them 1x/ week.
- Overspend on awareness ads unless you have a specific campaign running.



Do This Instead

- Use dashboards and tracking tools to automate and report on KPIs.
- Know what your baseline is - average it out by week and then by month. This will help you build momentum at the right time.
- Understand your competition and track their publicly available social and Google Business metrics.

5. Make Buying Easy by Reducing Friction

Small businesses can reduce buying friction by streamlining checkout processes, offering multiple payment options (like digital wallets), and providing upfront, transparent information on pricing, quotes or estimates and/or shipping.

Key strategies include implementing guest checkout, reducing form fields, optimizing for mobile speed, and limiting customer choices to avoid overwhelming new customers.

Is your business a service? Make sure you clarify on your website what you do and what you *don't* do in the “services” section.

Do you offer free estimates or discounted demos? Be descriptive and explicit in what you'll offer, what your customer will receive, and what the first step to engage with you is.

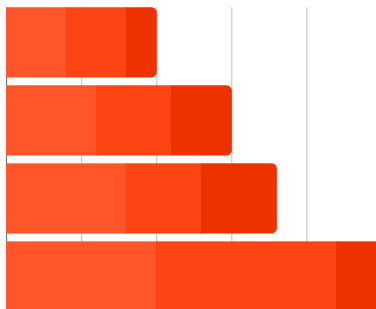
Another critical friction-point to reduce: Mobile Optimization! Ensure fast loading times and a mobile-friendly interface, as clunky mobile experiences drive customers away.

Our favorite tools to build and test your website speed and User Experience (UX):

- [Lovable](#) for AI-infused and easy website design (aka vibecoding)
- [SEMRush](#) for website insights
- [WAVE](#) for testing if your website is accessible friendly
- For more advanced marketers: [Page Speed Insights](#)

Don't Do This

- Create too many hoops for a new lead to jump through to learn more about your business.
- Post an email address or phone number for your business that's not constantly monitored.
- Give new leads only one way of being contacted
- many people prefer text or email to phone.



Do This Instead

- Be punctual about responding to new business inquiries.
- Keep any forms to simple, mission-critical info fields.
- Ensure your website is clean, simple, and mobile-optimized.

Ready to level up your marketing?



Visit www.LIBoostKit.com and download your customizable small business marketing toolkit. All the information, strategies and tactics you need to drive new business, improve your client relationships and maximize your brand presence.